

Story1

The last time I saw my mother at her home, it was July, a Sunday. I travelled there by train. At Motteville, we sat in the station for a long time. It was hot. It was quiet, both in the compartment and outside. I looked out the open window; the platform was empty. On the other side of the S.N.C.F. railroad barriers, the tall grass almost touched the lowest branches of the apple trees. It was then that I could really feel that I was approaching C. and that I was going to see my mother. The train continued on to C. at a reduced speed.

Leaving the station, I thought I recognized various faces, without being able to put a name to any of them. Perhaps I had never known the names. It was less hot, thanks to the wind. It's always windy in C. Everyone, including my mother, believes that it's colder in C. than in other places, even those just five kilometres away.

I didn't take the taxi that was parked in front of the railway hotel, as I would have anywhere else. As soon as I'm in C., I go back to my old ways: a taxi is for communions, weddings, and burials. There's no reason to spend money like that. I headed up Rue Carnot, to the town center. At the first pâtisserie, I bought cakes, éclairs, and apple tarts—the kind she used to tell me to bring home after midday Mass. I bought some flowers, too, gladioli, which last a long time. Until I got to the housing complex where she lives, I didn't think anything besides, I'm going to see her again and She's waiting for me.

I knocked on the narrow door of her ground-floor studio apartment. She called out, "Yes. Come in!

"You should lock the door!

"I knew it was you. There's no one else it could have been.

She was apronless, with lipstick on, laughing, standing by the table. She put her hand on my shoulder, tilting her face up for me to kiss. At the same time, she was firing off questions about my trip, the children, the dog. She didn't answer mine. Afraid of being boring, always, when speaking of herself. Later, she repeated, as usual, "I'm fine here. Couldn't be better and "I have no complaints. The TV was on without sound, just the test pattern on the screen.

She took the gladioli, a little uneasy, and thanked me with an artificial tone to her voice. I had forgotten: my giving her flowers from a florist had always seemed like an affectation to her, too formal; it hurt her feelings. It was as if I were fussing over her as I would over a stranger, not family. The cakes pleased her, but she had already bought some for us on her way back from Mass.

We sat opposite each other at the table that, along with the buffet, almost filled her apartment. I remembered what she'd said the first time I'd come here after she moved in: "I bought it big—it can seat at least ten people! Not once, in six years. . . . Nevertheless, she had covered it with an oilcloth, so as not to damage it.

She was breathless, as though she had no idea where to start among all the things we had to talk about. It was dark in her studio, and there was a slight odor; she didn't air it out enough. When I was a child, she'd take me with her to visit some old ladies on Sundays. Leaving their houses, she'd sniff the air: "It always smells so musty in old people's homes—they never open the windows. Because she used to say this, I hadn't expected her to become one of those people.

She talked about the weather in C. in the spring and the people who had died since my last visit, getting irritated with my failure to remember them, which she felt was intentional—"It's that you don't want to remember. Giving me detail after detail, until I could figure out whom she meant: the person lived there, her daughter went to school with me, and so on.

We set the table at quarter to twelve. The last time, she'd waited until twelve-thirty. She was accelerating everything. At one point, she said that the days of beautiful weather would soon be over.

While looking for napkins, I found a stack of romance magazines at the back of the buffet. I didn't say anything about them, but she guessed that I'd seen them. "Those little magazines—Paulette gives them to me, otherwise you know I wouldn't read them. That's all she reads, these little stories about nothing. Still afraid that I'd criticize her reading habits. I almost said that it didn't matter if she preferred *Nous Deux* to the Malraux she'd just borrowed from the public library. She would have been unhappy if I'd seemed to think her incapable of reading the kind of thing I read.

The meal passed in silence. Her eyes on her plate, her slightly sloppy movements those of someone used to eating alone. She refused to let me do the dishes.

"What will there be for me to do once you leave?

She was sitting up straight in her chair, her arms crossed. I'd never seen her move her body in a natural, relaxed way; she never ran her fingers gently through her hair, never slipped a hand inside the neckline of her blouse while deep in a book. Her only gestures of abandon were expressions of fatigue: stretching with her arms above her head, slumping in a chair, her legs out in front of her. Less hardness in her face than there had been, less of that tension you need to make your way through life. Her gray eyes, which had always suspected the worst of me, were fixed on me with a hungry softness. She had been counting the days, had told herself in the morning that this was the day I was coming, and there we were, the two of us, and half our time had already passed. The tone of our visit was playful and kind. The other tone, the violence from when I was fifteen, would not return. "Cow, bitch, I'm killing myself for her. "I'm going to get the fuck out of here. "You're going to jail first, you useless idiot.

She tried to come up with more subjects of conversation, so that I wouldn't go too soon, leaving her alone with her desire for me, her longing to live with me, her daughter, forever. "Paulette brought me some gooseberries. You wouldn't

believe how good they are. It makes sense, since they're in season. Remind me to give you some before you go. Paulette—a former neighbor who was my age—came to see her every week; she had never left C.

I could hear cars in the distance on the trunk road, a radio in the apartment next door, broadcasting the Tour de France, perhaps.

"It's peaceful.

"It's always peaceful here. Sundays are the quietest.

Many times she had advised me to get some rest during my vacation. The sentence that used to horrify me the most when I was complaining that I didn't know what to do: "Just have a little rest. Again, I felt the onset of annoyance, but her words had no power over me anymore. They only reawakened memories, the way sports radio on Sunday or an apple tart can. I could feel the boredom of summers in C.: reading from morning to night; Sunday movies, restricted or for adults only, in the three-quarters-empty theatre of the Mondial, while she thought I was out for a "nice walk with an older cousin; the children's games at the street fair for local businesses; the public dance hall, which I didn't dare enter.

In the middle of the afternoon, a cat appeared on the windowsill of the kitchenette. She jumped up from her armchair to let it in, an "adopted cat that she fed, that slept on her bed in the daytime. She was the happiest she'd been since I got there. The cat kept us busy for a long time—watching it, taking turns holding it. She recounted all its tricks; "the little pig clawed the curtains, and even her wrists, which were striped with red in two places. As she used to, she said, "Every living thing is beautiful. She seemed to have forgotten that I was going to leave.

At the last minute, she pulled out a form that urgently needed to be filled out for her Social Security. "I don't have time. Just give it to me and I'll send it to you. "It'll take no time. You're five minutes from the station. "I'll miss my train. "You've never missed it. You can take the next one. She was on the verge of tears. She concluded with her habitual "This is very upsetting for me.

After kissing me at the door, she tried to keep talking. Last image of her: in the doorway, rounded arms framing her heavy silhouette in a yellow dress—her prettiest one, tight around the chest and the belly—a wide, fixed smile. This time, once again, I felt that I was leaving badly, in a cowardly way.

I took the shortest route to the train, the one that goes past the Shell station. There, in the old days, I'd stop to prepare myself for her interrogating look when I returned from the cinema, bracing myself, wiping off what was left of my lipstick. What will people think of you?

On the train, I couldn't help imagining her, washing the dishes in a solitary silence, all sign of my presence soon erased. I watched C. disappear—the Sernam buildings, the railway workers' housing beside the tracks.

A month later, I came back to see my mother. She had suffered sunstroke after Mass and had been admitted to the hospital in C. I aired out her apartment, retrieved paperwork from her buffet, threw out the perishables in her fridge. In the vegetable drawer, in a plastic bag that was knotted at the top, were the gooseberries I had forgotten to take the previous time, now just a brown, liquid heap.

-----The End-----

Story2

As I stepped off the train and inhaled the familiar scent of freshly cut grass, I was transported back in time. The small town, nestled in the rolling hills of the countryside, seemed untouched by time. It had been a month since I last visited my elderly mother, and a wave of nostalgia had pulled me back to the place where my childhood memories were born.

Walking down the cobbled streets, I marveled at the quaint little houses with their white picket fences. The town seemed to buzz with life, a secret energy waiting to be unleashed. I felt a sense of belonging, as if I had never truly left.

Finally, I arrived at the old Victorian house that had been my mother's sanctuary for the past twenty years. Opening the door, I was greeted by the comforting aroma of her freshly baked apple pie. The scent enveloped me like a warm hug, reminding me of the love and warmth that always filled her home.

I found my mother sitting in her favorite armchair, her silver hair neatly pinned back, engrossed in a book. "Mother," I called out, concern evident in my voice.

She looked up, her eyes twinkling with delight. "Darling, you're here! Come, sit with me."

I settled into the worn-out armchair opposite her, its familiarity like a cozy embrace. We spent hours immersed in conversation, swapping stories and reminiscing about the past. As we laughed and shared memories, time seemed to stand still. Every word and every laugh echoed through the walls of our shared history, creating new memories to cherish.

The day slipped away like a whisper in the wind, and soon the sun began its descent into the horizon. Reluctantly, I bid my mother goodnight, promising to return again soon. The following days turned into weeks, and before I knew it, a month had passed.

Overwhelmed by guilt for not keeping my promise, I hurriedly made my way back to her house. Little did I know that this visit would be different, that the walls of nostalgia that had surrounded us before would crumble beneath the weight of reality.

As I entered the house, a chilling silence enveloped me, replacing the usual warmth and comfort. The scent of freshly baked pie had been replaced by a musty odor that seemed to cling to the air like sadness. My heart skipped a

beat as I stepped into the living room. The armchair that had held us both was now empty, devoid of its previous warmth.

In a daze, I wandered through the house, searching for any signs of life. The rooms were filled with remnants of our previous visit, frozen in time. The book my mother had been reading lay abandoned on the coffee table, its pages untouched. It was just as I had left it, a month ago.

My footsteps echoed through the empty halls as I climbed up the stairs, my anxiety mounting with every step. In her bedroom, I found her, lying motionless on the bed, frail and fragile like a bird with broken wings. The sun had taken its toll on her delicate frame, leaving her helpless and vulnerable.

Tears welled up in my eyes as I sat beside her, clutching her frail hand in mine. Memories of our last visit replayed in my mind, the laughter and connection we had shared now haunting me, like a whisper of a distant melody.

Days turned into weeks once more, but this time it was spent in the sterile confines of a hospital room. Machines beeped rhythmically, their coldness contrasting sharply with the warmth that used to emanate from my mother's presence.

I kept vigil by her side, reading to her from the very same book she had been engrossed in during our last conversation. The stories from its pages filled the room, intertwining with the memories of our shared past. I hoped, prayed, that she could hear me, that the sound of my voice could somehow bring her back to me.

There were moments when her eyes would flutter open, and a faint smile would grace her lips. It was in those moments that I felt a glimmer of hope. The bond we shared could not be severed by the cruel hands of time or the trials of life.

As the days turned into months, my mother's health slowly improved. She regained her strength, her spirit, and the light in her eyes flickered back to life. We returned to her small town, to the place where our memories were born, where our stories had unfolded.

And so, we spent our days together, walking hand in hand down the cobbled streets, sharing stories and laughter that seemed to echo through the hills. The sun no longer posed a threat, for I was there to shield her from its harsh rays, to protect her from harm.

It was in those moments, surrounded by the gentle embrace of our small town, that I realized the strength of our bond. Regardless of the trials we faced, the passing of time, or the hurdles that life threw our way, our love would always endure.

And so, we savored each moment, for we knew that our time together was a gift. The remnants of our last visit held no sadness or regret, but rather served as a reminder of the resilience of the human spirit, of the power of love to transcend even the harshest of realities.

Through the seasons, we watched as the town transformed. Each change brought new stories and memories, etching themselves into the tapestry of our lives. We shared laughter and tears, celebrations and challenges, drawing strength from each other's presence.

As the years went by, our small town became a testament to the power of love and community. We witnessed weddings, births, and farewells, and through it all, our bond remained unbreakable. We became an integral part of the tapestry, woven into the very fabric of the town.

When my mother's time finally came, her departure left a void in our small town and in my heart. Yet, I sought solace in the memories we had created, the laughter we had shared, and the love we had nurtured. She may be physically gone, but her spirit lives on.

I continued to walk the cobbled streets, tracing the well-worn paths that held the echoes of our steps. The town embraced me, offering comfort and solace in its familiar embrace. The memories we had forged became my guiding light, reminding me to embrace life, cherish moments, and always keep love alive.

Years later, I sit down to write the story of my mother. It is a tale of love and resilience, of a bond that transcended time and tested the limits of the human heart.

My mother, with her silver hair and twinkling eyes, was a force of nature. She taught me the importance of kindness, of embracing every moment as if it were the last. Her small town, with its cobbled streets and white picket fences, became the backdrop for the remarkable story that unfolded between us.

Together, we weathered the storms of life, finding solace in the embrace of the community that surrounded us. We shared laughter and tears, creating a tapestry of memories that would forever be etched in my heart.

But it wasn't always easy. There were moments when the weight of the world seemed too much to bear. Times when the challenges of aging threatened to break our spirits. Yet, we stood strong, drawing strength from each other and the love that bound us.

As the years passed, my mother's health began to deteriorate. The once vibrant woman who had fought battles and overcome obstacles found herself needing my help. I became her rock, her caregiver, even as I struggled to come to terms with the role reversal between us.

And so, we embarked on a new chapter of our journey. Days turned into months, and months into years, as we navigated the uncharted territory of aging and illness. Together, we faced doctors' appointments, hospital stays, and the uncertainty that came with each passing day.

But through it all, we never lost sight of the love that connected us. Even in the darkest moments, there was always a glimmer of light, a reminder of the

bond we shared. We held onto that light, even as the world around us seemed to grow dim.

And then, one fateful day, my mother's time came to an end. The void she left behind was immense, a testament to the impact she had on the lives she touched. But in the midst of my grief, I found solace in the memories we had created, the love that had bound us together.

Her small town, our small town, mourned her loss. The bells of the local church tolled in a somber tribute to a life well-lived. And as I walked the cobbled streets one last time, I could hear the echoes of her laughter, the sound of her footsteps beside me.

In the years that followed, I found comfort in the embrace of the community she had been a part of. They reminded me of her spirit, her kindness, and they helped me find my way forward. Our small town, once the backdrop of our story, became a beacon of hope and resilience.

And now, as I sit here, penning the final chapter of our tale, I am reminded of the power of love. How it can transcend time and transcend even death. My mother may no longer be with me in body, but her spirit lives on in every act of kindness, in every moment of laughter, and in every memory we created together.

I will forever cherish our time in that small town, in that house that held so much love. And I will continue to walk the cobbled streets, tracing the well-worn paths that held the echoes of our steps. I will carry her in my heart, always, and strive to live a life that honors her legacy.

For in the end, it is through love that we find our purpose, that we find our way home. And as I close this chapter of our story, I know that our love will endure, forever etched in the fabric of our small town and in the depths of my soul.

-----The End-----

Story3

When I pulled up to the house, for the first time in more years than I cared to count, I found my mother standing on the stoop, a sunbonnet adorning her head, her small face peering out from beneath the wide white brim like a turtle's from beneath its shell. She had never seemed so quaint; I had not realized that the years of separation—years filled with bustling cities and the intense, absorbing world of sophisticated science—had invaded my memory and slowly remodeled her image into something almost fashionable. It was only with the sight of the sunbonnet that the illusion shattered, returning her to my mind's eye as she truly was: a little stiff, a little arthritic, a little stoop-shouldered, but with the valiant spirit undiminished, still only a finger's width beneath the skin.

She was in her morning wrapper, a cashmere shawl draped around her shoulders, the drabest of slippers on her feet, and she wore this disarray with the preoccupied ease of royalty at home, leaning with one hand on the cane she had

only recently begun to use, and waving the other with the flick of an archduke's plumes in my general direction.

With a light chuckle, I exclaimed, "Well! You're looking exceptionally distinguished these days." I lifted her hand and clicked my heels together like a diplomat under presentation to the Court of a minor principality. As I did so, I took in the humbler details about her that I had so long forgotten – like the tiny potted plants that flanked the doorway, and the soft, curling strands of her silver-tinged hair.

One corner of her mouth twitched with the ember of a reluctant smile, but her eyes remained serious. "No foolishness," she admonished gently. "How are you, my dear?"

I knew precisely what she meant by the question, and I assured her that I was well again. And yet she continued to gaze at me, studying my face with a tender concern that only a mother can render. "Humph!" she said at last, her chest heaving with a sigh that carried the weight of her unspoken thoughts. Then she nodded slowly, bracing herself for what was to come, and turned to lead me into the house.

The sunlight streaming through the open doorway lapsed into silence, heavy with the accumulated weight of all my years away from her. Within that time there had been new life brought into the world, the passing of loved ones, the births of scholars who had not even considered their theses when I last stood in this room, along with wars plotted, and then bled upon the world stage. Calms, too, were restored upon the earth and in the heavens. What a strange experience it was to accompany my mother once more, her shawl brushing against the wall, her cane tapping in front of her. As I looked around me, I saw the familiar hangings intermingled with samplers and Japanese screens in their unaltered niches, all of which had borne witness to the endless progression of hours, days, and years ticking away beneath the portrait of my father.

I stayed with her for one week; during that time, we spent countless hours conversing, either in the soft warmth of the parlor or in the dim twilight of the fragrant garden after supper. There, she would sit wrapped in shawls, shielding herself against the damp evening air. At times, I would sink into the embrace of the cushioned veranda chairs, leaving my collar open to the honey-thick, heavy-scented breeze, as I smoked meditatively and reminisced about my younger days in the very same town. Together we resurrected memories of the germinating seeds of my ambition, whilst I dug into the hidden depths of connection with that younger version of myself, all the while emboldened by her presence.

The town's picturesque streets were lined with flowers and fringed with dappled patches of sunlight, coaxing forth a murmur of echoes that dissolved under the soft glow of quaint lamplight. The local shopkeepers I encountered, and the few old acquaintances who unexpectedly crossed my path, would squint into my now aged eyes as they sought the child who had long vanished into the swirling mists of time. For each of them, I took on the role of a nostalgic visitor, all

the while cloaking my keen observation of change and constancy with a veil of detachment. These encounters lent a surreal air to our conversations as we basked in the gentle radiance.

As the days wore on, I found myself struck by a profound revelation, one that lingered with me long after the visit had ended. For as complicated as the tapestry of our intertwined lives may have been, and as diverse as our shared experiences often proved to be, it gradually dawned upon me that the very core of my mother's and my history could be uncovered within those very walls. The essence of our connection lay secure in the fragile heart of a small, aging woman who sat gently tapping her cane against the floor while retelling her stories, reflecting on our past, and pondering the hazy uncertainty of what lay ahead.

The week drew swiftly to a close, and all too soon, I was saying my farewells and preparing to depart the comforts of home once more. Mother did her best to hide her sadness, of course, but I saw the quiet grief simmering below the surface as she waved me off down the driveway and back into the cold embrace of the vast world beyond.

But if I had thought to leave the echoes of a summer visit safely entombed in their customary haunts, fate, it seemed, had other plans for me. The end of the following month brought with it a letter from the doctor, who did not mince words. "You will have realized by now that your mother is not as young as she once was," he wrote. "In fact, it is only right that I should tell you the truth: she is old—quite old. She seems to have aged a great deal recently. This sunstroke, of course—"

The news came as a shock, albeit not a terrible one. For I reassured myself with the knowledge that the doctor did not necessarily expect my mother to die, at least not in the immediate future. After all, he himself wrote, "This is a resilient generation: I have seen them recover."

"You should come if you can," he added, "even if only for a short visit." And so, with resignation weighing heavy in my heart, I returned home to her side.

Upon my arrival, I found the house apparently unchanged, as if locked in a time capsule of its own making. The exterior world has a remarkable capacity for preserving its façade while the wheels of time continue to grind away within. Even so, something subtle and intangible was amiss: the windows seemed-muted, more diffuse than I remembered them, as if they strained to hold back tears. I could sense my mother's absence engulfing the once warm and vibrant dwelling, permeating the very structure and transforming it into an echoing void.

Returning to the house felt both like stepping into another era and having never-left at all. The sight of Mother's cane lying idly against the armchair awoke a deep nostalgia within me, and in that moment, I was transported back in time, traveling with her once again into the realm of my childhood memories. The patterns on the fireplace tiles where she would sit and knit were as familiar as my own reflection, whispering of the quiet moments we had spent together,

murmuring about family history, and exchanging tales of the damask European capitals where her father had wandered in his own spirited youth.

As I wandered through the house, each room revealed new remnants of my last visit. In her bedroom, I noticed the crumpled scarf I had bought her; I could recall the scene where I playfully draped it over her shoulders, laughing as the vibrant colors clashed almost comically with her otherwise dull wardrobe. In the parlor, the worn pages of the books we had perused together lay open, eagerly awaiting our return to share in the fascinations we had unearthed and to ponder the enigmas of their authors.

Our conversations may have seemed like nothing more than whispers, barely audible above the din of adult life, but they now appeared tangible, etched into the very fabric of the room that still echoed their presence.

The hush that enveloped the house was disrupted only by the familiar ticking of the old clock. Its rhythmic cadence was as certain and unstinting in its duty as a soldier on march, serving as a sobering reminder that the world waited for no one, not even my mother. It brought to mind her percussive gait, the tapping of her cane barely a beat ahead of my footfall, as well as her determined refusal to walk any other path in life than the one she had so stoically chosen.

"She is old—quite old," the doctor had written, and indeed, his words held true. I saw her face in the mirror, the deep-set lines of age etched across her skin, her spirit waning under the heavy burden of her years.

That boy I once was, who had been nurtured and taught to look at the world and dare to dream big, had vanished, and in his place stood the man I had become. Undeniably, her unwavering presence had shaped me, and yet, it now struck me how I had taken her existence for granted, confident in the belief that she would forever endure, an immortal anchor amidst the stormy seas of my journey.

As I stood in the shadows of my childhood home while the sun dipped below the horizon, casting ethereal streaks of fading light into the omnipresent mist, I could almost feel my younger self clinging onto her robes in the form of an eternal promise. A promise of company and protection even in life's most turbulent times; a bond of love as unwavering as the passage of the sun across the sky. And perhaps it was that last glimmer of light – the echo of a previous life – that called me back, just for one more night, to seek sanctuary within the walls of a house that bore witness to the passage of our lives, leaving me to reflect on how much time we had left together and to treasure the lingering echoes of a shared history that shaped us both.

-----The End-----

Story4

The familiar rumble of my station wagon felt bittersweet as I set out for the five-hour drive to Spring Meadows. Excitement at seeing my mother mingled

with worry over what shape I might find her in. At 80, her health had become delicately unpredictable. After a lifetime of shared moments and cherished summer afternoons, each visit felt more poignant and final. I didn't want to lose such a central part of my world. Time felt scarce and precious in a way it never had before.

I stopped at a gas station to fill up, buying a coffee and a couple snacks to keep me going on the long drive ahead. My mind wandered as I watched the numbers on the gas pump climb higher and higher, thinking of all the road trips and adventures Mom and I had shared over the years. We were always setting off spontaneously on little getaways, seeking new sights and making new memories. I remembered all the small towns we had explored, stopping at diners and antique stores along the way. Mom had a way of turning every little errand into an adventure. I smiled at the thought of how indignant Mom would get if I suggested she might be getting too old for such escapades. Her sense of wanderlust and curiosity had not faded with age. If anything, she lived with a heightened awareness of how ephemeral each moment was, how many more adventures might still await if we only set out to find them.

The long stretch of highway winding through forests and valleys lulled me into a meditative state as I traveled the well-worn path back to my childhood home. Miles passed in a blur of green and gold as my mind wandered through memories of the past. The diner where Mom and I always stopped for pie after school—Mom always got apple, I always got cherry. The movie theater where I had my first kiss at 15, with Danny McPhee in the back row. The corner store that still boasted the same vintage peppermint-stick candy in its window that Mom would buy me as a treat when money was tight but joy was abundant. Everything felt preserved in amber, untouched for 30 years as if keeping it safe for my return.

Her house sat at the end of Maple Street, a well-kept Victorian with lemon-yellow shutters and an immaculate lawn. Before I could knock, the door swung open. "There's my darling!" Mom pulled me into a hug with strength that belied her age. The comforting smell of Chanel No. 5 and coffee enveloped me as her familiar laugh, as warm and sweet as blueberry pie, bubbled up. We settled into a leisurely visit, stepping back into our usual routine as if no time had passed. I made us tuna salad sandwiches, heavy on the pickles, while Mom set out glasses of iced tea garnished with mint from her garden. The sunlight filtering through the gauzy curtains gave the kitchen a dreamy, timeless quality as we flipped through old photo albums, laughing over hairstyles and outfits long gone. We lingered over pictures of my father, gone nearly fifteen years now, and spoke of him with more tenderness than pain, his memory a shared and well-worn storybook of happier days.

After eating, I did the dishes while Mom disappeared into the study to do her daily crossword. The familiarity was soothing, wrapping itself around me like a cozy blanket. For a few fleeting hours, I could pretend nothing had changed, that I was an inquisitive girl again spending the summer with her mother, with not

a care in the world beyond whatever adventure we might discover together that day. I peered through her doorway stealthily and my heart warmed upon seeing her face so focused, brows furrowed in concentration, pencil tapping against her lip. Mom always did this whenever she was trying to figure out a particularly tricky clue. I smiled, thinking if only this small precious moment could last forever.

I joined her in the study and we tackled the crossword together, my literary acumen complementing her decades of experience. The world outside faded away as we immersed ourselves in clues and black-and-white boxes, as we always used to, debating and hypothesizing for hours until the puzzle was solved. We high-fived in triumph upon completion, a goofy little ritual we had shared for as long as I could remember. The familiar sounds and smells enveloped me like a hug. I started preparing dinner as Mom set the table, slicing vegetables and browning meat for a hearty beef stew. The smell of the hearty stew was wafting through the house, bringing back memories of childhood. We continued chatting as we ate together in the dining room instead of in front of the TV like usual, savoring each bite and laughing over memories of the day's victories and defeats.

Rain began to patter on the windows as evening fell, the soothing sound of droplets on leaves outside lulling us into contentment. When nightfall came we made popcorn and watched old movies we had memorized, line by line, commenting and giggling over forgotten details. We stayed up talking until the early hours of the morning, catching up on all the little details, big and small, that made up the fabric of our daily lives. Though we spoke on the phone often, nothing compared to chatting with my mom in person. Her laugh and smile lifted my spirits in a way our phone calls just couldn't replicate.

The next morning I made blueberry pancakes and we ate them on the back patio, the scent of freshly mown grass and roses mingling in the warm air. We browsed seed catalogs and made plans for new flowers we would plant together in the spring, clinging to those promises of shared seasons to come. I clipped flowers and made garlands for her hair as I used to do as a child. She wore them with regal grace, and just for a moment the hands of time seemed to spin in reverse.

We spent the afternoon out in the garden, planting petunias and geraniums in the flower boxes as we always did. With dirt under our fingernails and the sun warm on our backs, everything felt as it always had. I dug my hands into the cool earth, feeling like a child again as Mom taught me how to properly space the seedlings. Her garden was always a sea of vibrant blooms come summer, and I looked forward to when I might return and find it alive with color. When evening came we made a simple dinner of grilled cheese and tomato soup, and stayed up late watching the moon rise over the fields beyond the garden, silver light flooding the furrows and rows where our lives had grown together over the decades. I didn't want the day to end, knowing with the dawn I would have to return home.

When I returned a month later, it was not for a pleasant visit but because Mom had landed in the hospital after a fall in the garden left her with a broken hip and wrist. The doctors said the injuries would heal, but at her age, it was hard to say how fully. My heart sank at the thought of losing my best friend, the woman who had loved me unconditionally my whole life.

The house felt different without the usual sounds of Mom puttering around. I wandered into the kitchen where our lunch dishes from last month still sat—two plates with crumbs, two glasses with dredges of mint leaves. Such a little thing, but it pierced my heart, a reminder of the fragile and fleeting moments we had left.

Mom returned home fragile but defiant. "I've still got some life in me yet," she said, arranging a vase of fresh flowers with her good arm. "We've got more crosswords to conquer." We didn't speak of how close we had come to losing her, to losing the life we had always known together. The hours stretched quiet and bittersweet, as if a stopwatch had been set ticking down in the background. But we continued the routine—the sandwiches, the crosswords, the laughter when it arose unexpectedly—each moment knitting together into memories I would cherish for the life we had left.

One crisp autumn day, Mom passed away peacefully in her sleep. I found her in the study, the half-finished crossword still on her lap, filled with her familiar script. My heart shattered into a thousand pieces. I felt adrift without my anchor, alone for the first time.

At the funeral, I spoke of the little moments we had shared over tuna sandwiches and crosswords and flower crowns, the magical halcyon days of my childhood and our remaining bittersweet hours together. I said that in the end, a life comes down to overflowing photo albums, inside jokes, and knowing glances across a familiar kitchen. It comes down to little moments knitted together, and the memories they leave behind. Memories I would carry with me always, in the stained-glass corridors of my heart.

-----The End-----

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